

# Executive Summary — Care Transition Efficiency & Placement Outcome Analytics

**Audience:** HHS / programme leadership and government stakeholders **Dataset:** HHS Unaccompanied Alien Children (UAC) daily reporting file · 12 Jan 2023 – 21 Dec 2025 · 720 reports over 1,075 calendar days  
**Deliverables:** this summary · full research paper (PDF) · live Streamlit dashboard

## Bottom line

The programme is usually described by **how many** children are in care. This analysis measures **how well children move through care**: border handoff speed, discharge velocity, backlog growth and the consistency of reunification outcomes.

On that basis the pipeline is structurally sound at stage 1 and weak at stage 2, and **the most recent year is the weakest on record for process — not because it is busier, but because it is slower**:

Between 2023 and 2025 the transfer of children from CBP to HHS slowed from **83% to 46%** of the border queue per day (1.3 → 3.3 days to clear), and the daily discharge of children to sponsors fell from **3.34% to 0.90%** of the HHS caseload — stretching the implied reunification cycle from **31 days to a median of 177 days**. Meanwhile the Outcome Stability Score, which measures how consistent daily release performance is, fell from **77.7 to 0.0**.

Capacity counts alone would have reported "caseload down, numbers good." Process metrics show reunification speed deteriorating roughly six-fold over the same period.

## What was measured

The programme is modelled as a three-stage pipeline with two queues:

**Apprehension → [CBP custody] → transfer → [HHS care] → discharge → sponsor placement**

Five headline KPIs, all scale-invariant so years with very different volumes are comparable:

| KPI                           | Definition                                       | Full period                           |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Transfer Efficiency Ratio     | Transfers ÷ children in CBP custody              | <b>69.1%/day</b> (≈2.0 days to clear) |
| Discharge Effectiveness Index | Discharges ÷ children in HHS care                | <b>2.37%/day</b> (≈98 days to place)  |
| Pipeline Throughput           | Total exits ÷ total entries                      | <b>1.85×</b>                          |
| Backlog Accumulation Rate     | Transfers – discharges, per report               | <b>–45/day</b> (net drain)            |
| Outcome Stability Score       | 100 × (1 – variation in discharge effectiveness) | <b>43.9 / 100</b>                     |

Window totals: **67,337 apprehensions → 92,641 transfers → 124,853 sponsor placements**.

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## Five findings

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**1. The border handoff is fast; the placement stage is 50× slower.** Children leave CBP custody in about **2 days**; the HHS caseload takes about **98 days** to place at observed rates. Reform effort belongs at stage 2.

**2. 2024 was the backlog year.** It is the only year in which discharges failed to keep pace with transfers (placement completion **98%**, net **+3.4 children/day**). The detector found **36 sustained accumulation runs** covering 170 reports and a cumulative 7,787 children — **27 of those 36 runs, and 7,595 of those children, fall in 2024**. The single worst episode: **+1,028 children accumulated between 21 April and 2 May 2024 (12 days)** — an event invisible in monthly averages.

**3. 2025 lost speed, not just volume.** Intake fell from 148 to 13 children/day and the caseload fell ~64% — but transfer efficiency halved, discharge effectiveness fell ~4×, the implied placement cycle stretched to **227 days (mean)**, and **every one of the 190 sub-threshold release reports and 141 slow-release alerts in the entire three-year record occurred in 2025**. The worst single month-over-month move was **-73.4% (March 2025)**.

**4. Two prolonged low-reunification windows and nine sudden drops were located precisely.** Longest stagnation: **11–31 March 2025** — 15 consecutive reports at 0.30%/day against a 1.19% baseline (a 74% shortfall sustained 21 days). Second: **17–26 February 2025**. Nine sudden drops ( $\geq 2\sigma$  below the trailing mean) cluster in Jan–Feb and Nov 2025.

**5. Releases appear to be batched at weekends — and the data cannot confirm it.** Sunday reports carry **+61 more discharges** than weekday reports at equal caseload, gap and trend ( $t = 9.7$ ). But the file has **no Saturday reports and only two Friday reports**, so weekend activity and a wider weekend counting window cannot be told apart. **33% of calendar days (355 of 1,075) carry no report at all.**

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## Recommended actions

| # | Action                                                                  | Trigger / target                                                                                       | Why                                                                                                                      |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Publish a <b>discharge-velocity floor</b>                               | Discharge Effectiveness $\geq$ <b>2.5%/day</b> ( $\approx$ 40-day cycle) with automatic alert below 1% | 2025 median cycle is 177 days; all 190 breaches are in 2025                                                              |
| 2 | Set a <b>CBP handoff service level</b>                                  | Transfer Efficiency $\geq$ 60% / clearance $\leq$ 2 days                                               | Actual 2025: 46% and 3.3 days                                                                                            |
| 3 | <b>Three-report accumulation trigger</b>                                | Intervene on the 3rd consecutive report of queue growth                                                | Every one of the 36 runs began as a 3-day streak; worst added 1,028 children in 12 days                                  |
| 4 | <b>Move to seven-day reporting</b> and publish a <b>data dictionary</b> | Coverage 67% $\rightarrow$ $\geq$ 95%; close the 2023 reconciliation gap                               | 355 unobserved days; 2023 flow columns leave <b><math>\approx</math>151 children/day unexplained</b> vs the stock change |
| 5 | <b>Review any month scoring &lt; 50 on stability</b>                    | March 2025 scored 14.4                                                                                 | Erratic release cadence disrupts shelter staffing, transport and school enrolment downstream                             |

## Data caveats a decision-maker should know

- **Stock and flow columns do not reconcile in 2023.** Reported transfers minus discharges predict a 30,120-child drawdown while the queue actually grew by 4,664 — an unexplained **+34,784 children ( $\approx$ 151/day)**. The identity closes to  $\pm 4$ /day by 2025. Within-period ratios are unaffected, but absolute 2023 volumes should not be audited against each other until a data dictionary exists.
- **Reporting is Monday–Thursday plus Sundays** — no Saturdays, two Fridays, a longest blind spot of 10 days.
- **No child-level data.** True length-of-stay, sponsor type and post-discharge outcomes are out of scope; "release time" is a flow/stock proxy.
- **The analysis is descriptive, not causal.** The 2025 break is documented, not attributed to any specific policy.

## What the dashboard delivers

`streamlit run app.py` opens five modules: **Care Pipeline Flow** (stocks, flows and a flow-conserving pipeline map), **Transfer & Discharge Efficiency** (with a *counts / ratios / days-to-clear* toggle), **Bottleneck Detection** (sustained runs, alert histogram), **Outcome Trend Analysis** (month-over-month placements, stability, weekday/weekend) and **Data & Method** (coverage, mass balance, definitions, CSV downloads).

Controls: **date-range selection**, **ratio-based metric toggles**, **rolling-window smoothing** and four **threshold-based visual alerts** — every chart marks the reports that breach the thresholds you set.

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*All figures are regenerated from the source CSV by `python src/run_analysis.py` ; supporting tables are in `outputs/tables/` and machine-readable findings in `outputs/insights.json` .*